The ATS "parsing problem" isn't an AI mystery.

Every week, job seekers are told to pay resume gurus to beat Applicant Tracking Systems advanced, AI-driven black boxes. As a data engineer with 30 years in the field, I find that hard to take seriously.



We solved this in the 1980s.

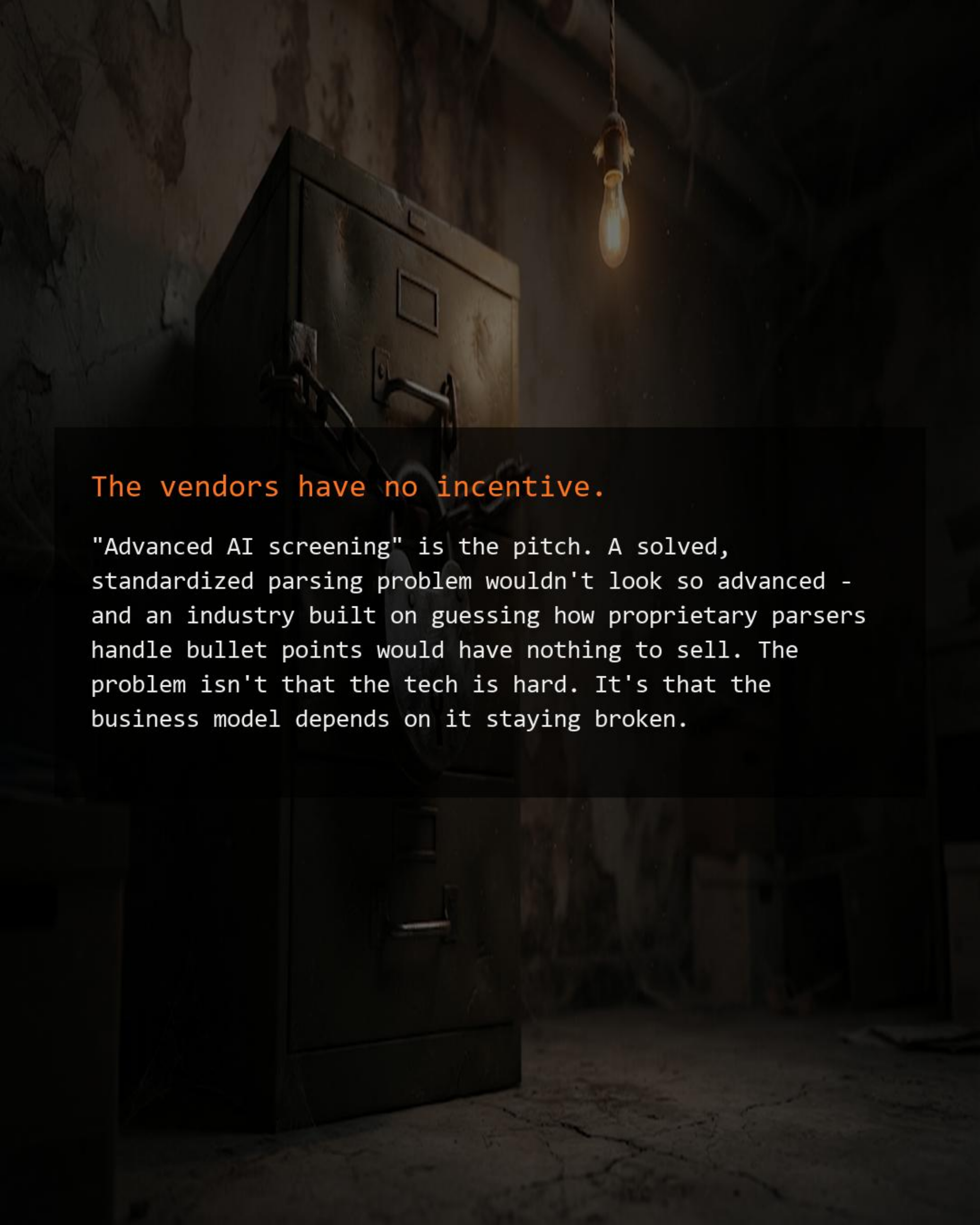
We've been transmitting and parsing standardized business documents for forty years. EDI isn't just a transmission method - it's a rigid format with a defined schema, and parsing it is a solved problem. Every parser reads an 850 purchase order the same way, because there's nothing to guess.

The engineering is the easy part.

Drop bloated, styled documents for raw text or Markdown. Enforce rigid, standardized headers - # Experience, # Skills, # Education. Map it straight into a relational database with a lightweight parser. 100% Ingestion accuracy. No data loss. No formatting corruption.

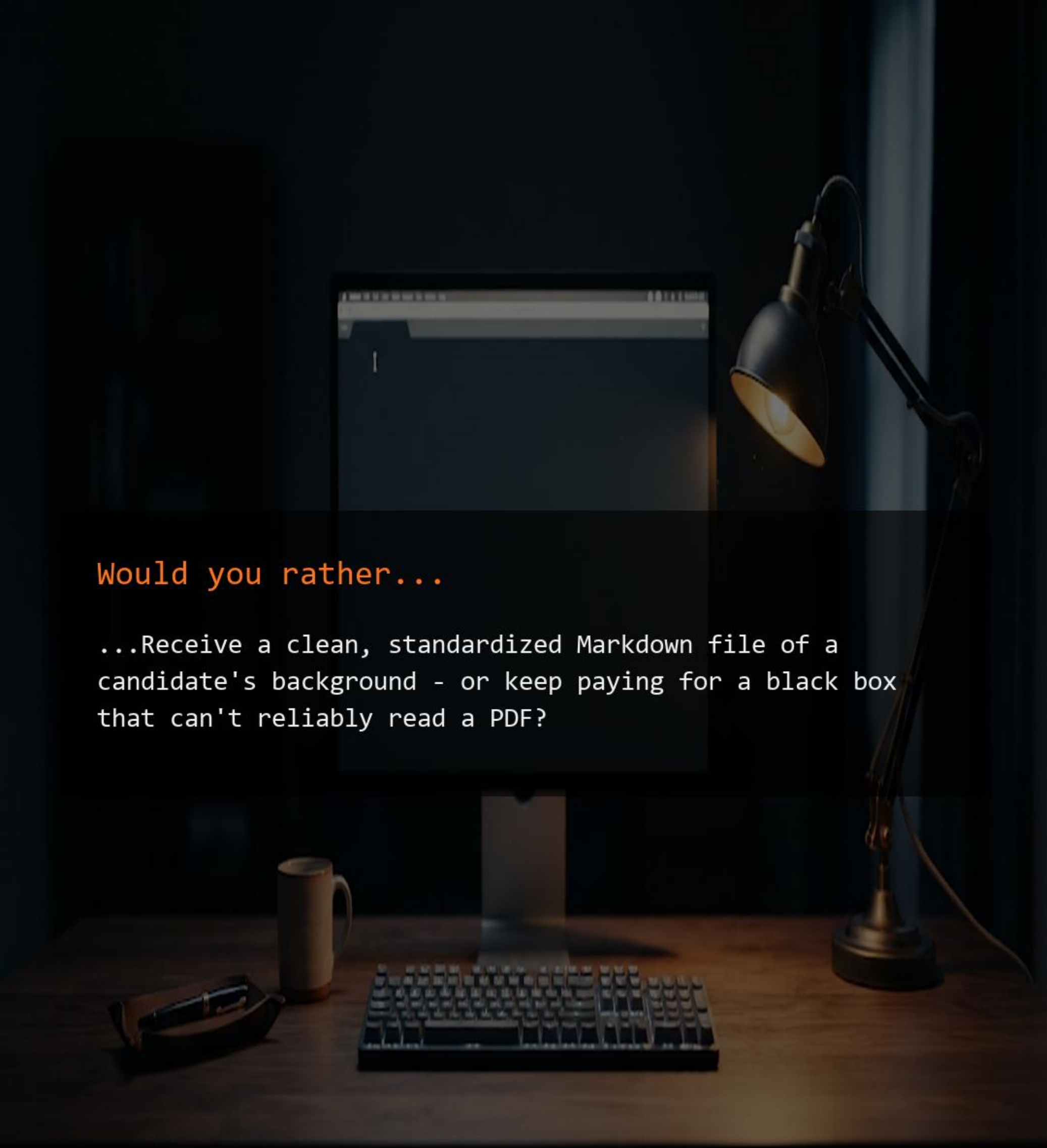
So why hasn't it happened?

Not because it's technically hard - because it's a coordination problem disguised as a technology problem. Resumes are unstructured by nature, and fixing that means getting applicants, universities, career coaches, and ATS vendors to agree on a format.



The vendors have no incentive.

"Advanced AI screening" is the pitch. A solved, standardized parsing problem wouldn't look so advanced - and an industry built on guessing how proprietary parsers handle bullet points would have nothing to sell. The problem isn't that the tech is hard. It's that the business model depends on it staying broken.



Would you rather...

...Receive a clean, standardized Markdown file of a candidate's background - or keep paying for a black box that can't reliably read a PDF?